The day Princess Glimmer of Brightmoon was kidnapped by a mysterious but handsome archer

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by Bagge

Summary

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"Queen Angella, I bear grave news."

Angella, Queen of Brightmoon, put down her letter and gave her guard, knight and confidant a tired look.

"Grave news, Juliet?"

"Grave news indeed, my queen."

Angella sighed. She sat up straighter in the chair and put on her best queenly face. "Very well, Juliet. Let me know what new hardship the world has seen fit to place on the shoulders of a poor queen."

"It appears, my queen, that princess Glimmer of Brightmoon - your daughter and heir to the moonstone and the moonthrone - has been kidnapped."

Angella's eyes widened in shock. "My baby? KIDNAPPED? Juliet? What are you saying? We have to..." Angella's voice trailed off as she took in her knight's demeanor. Stone faced and formal, and far too calm for it to be a real emergency.

Angella calmed herself to calm down and looked Juliet in the eyes.

"Kidnapped, Juliet?"

A smiled lurked in the edge of Juliet's mouth. "Kidnapped, my queen."

After the initial shock, Angella felt a giddiness bubble up in her. But she kept up the facade with the ease of someone who has been queen for far too many years.

"And how - if I may ask, my knight - have these ill tidings presented themselves?"

"It seems, my queen, that the kidnapper saw fit to leave a note in the princess' chambers."

Angella nodded thoughtfully. "A note, you say."

"Yes, indeed, my queen. A note."

"And how, if I may ask, was this note delivered?"

"The note was..." Juliet did her best to keep the laughter from breaking through. "The note was tied... to... an arrow."

Angella valiantly tried to stop herself from laughing, but the look on Juliet's face was enough to make a very unqueenly giggle break through. "An arrow?"

"An arrow, my... queen."

With a flourished motion, Juliet plonked a short shafted arrow - which they both clearly recognized from the archery set Angella had given Glimmer's best friend Bow not even a year before - on the table in front of Angella. Around it was a piece of paper tied to the shaft in pink string.

The sight of the arrow was enough to make Angella start to laugh, which immediately set Juliet off. Eventually they managed to calm down enough to sit down. All thought of protocol forgotten, Angella poured a cup of tea to herself and Juliet from her ever filled pot (one of the perks of being queen). She picked up the arrow.

"Let's see what demands our nefarious assailant has given for the safe return of my daughter."

They eagerly scanned the paper - pulled from Glimmer's journal and written in pink glitter pen with hearts dotting the i:s.

"It would seem a ransom is demanded," Angella noted.

"In cookies," Juliet said, barely able to keep from laughter. "An entire tin of them."

"To be delivered by the treehouse," Angella giggled.

"Oh no, what's this!" Juliet pointed at the last line. "If we fail to meet these demands, the princess will meet a grizzly end."

"Well, we can't have that." Angella stood up in queenly determination. "You better make haste to the kitchen and have them make the necessary preparations. For my daughter's sake, and for all of the kingdom, we must pay the cookie price."

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"Are you sure this is all right?" Bow gave Glimmer a worried look.

"Of course it's all right. It's the perfect plan. Mom is always going on about how dangerous the world can be for a poor princess. Now she gets to be right and we gets to have cookies. Win, win."

"But what if they figure out it was me? They will banish me. Or throw me in the dungeon. Or feed me to a crocodile."

Glimmer made a sour face. "We don't have a dungeon. OR a crocodile, which is totally lame. I bet princess Mermista has a crocodile."

Bow pondered that. "Or maybe a shark."

"Or a giant squid."

"Or a manta ray."

"Or a killer whale."

"Or a sea horse."

Glimmer gave Bow a scornful look. "Sea horses are not scary."

"No, but they are pretty."

Glimmer's featured softened and she patted Bow on the arm. "You are right. Sea horses are pretty. I bet princess Mermista has a sea horse."

"Being thrown to the sea horses wouldn't be so bad," Bow thoughtfully said. "It would be a bit like walking the plank, I think. Pirates walk the plank all the time."

"If the pirates do it, it must be all right," Glimmer said in the happy certainty that she had won the argument. "And mom will never figure it's you anyway. She thinks you are too nice to kidnap me."

"I am too nice to kidnap you."

"You HAVE kidnapped me," Glimmer pointed out.

"Only because you told me to."

"And it was very nice of you to do so, which is why mom will never suspect you. As long as you stick to the next part of the plan."

"Right... the next part of the plan." Bow picked up the heavy black cloak. "Are you *sure* this is all right?"

- - -

"Oh, woe is me, a poor mother bereft of her daughter, as the kingdom is bereft of its princess."

"Yeah, my queen. Bummer."

"Your stoic demeanour, even in the face of tragedy as grave as this, does your credit my knight."

"Yeah, my queen. Credit."

"Hark! We have reached the tree house, the place where the fiendish abductor stipulated we were to hand over the ransom."

Angella and Juliet theatrically looked around. The tree house was expertly crafted by the royal carpenters, in a huge tree near the edge of one of the many royal gardens. On one side the castle

wall towered - even more pink then usual from the light of the setting sun. In all other directions were tasteful paths trailing between flower beds and shrubberies and a few trees - slightly glowing from residual magic emissions. There was no one else in sight.

"Where might the dastardly brigand hide do you think, my knight?"

"Dunno, my Queen."

As on cue, a pink light flashed behind them, and the gravel shifted as someone quickly regained their footing. Angella and Juliet dutifully waited until they heard a polite 'Um, excuse me', immediately followed by a much lower, growled 'I mean, I hope you brought the cookies.'

They turned around and did their best not to laugh as they stood face to face with Bow, wearing a fake beard, an eyepatch and a heavy, hooded cloak, doing his best (not very) to look menacing. His balanced on a pair of stilts, which put him on eye level with Juliet, with Angella still towering over him. At the sight of him she took a quick step back clutching her hands over her heart.

"Egads! A villain! I implore you, my brave knight, defend me against this frightful menace."

Juliet took a quick step in front of the queen, staring at the ground rather than the masked child, least she would start laughing again. "Be brave, my queen. For Glimmer's sake."

"You are right, my knight. For the sake of my beloved daughter I will face this dreadful terror. Oh woe! Oh woe!"

"Um, did you bring... I mean, scurvy landlubbers. I trust you brought the booty."

Juliet quickly turned away and bit her glove. She was shaking as she forced herself to remain silent. Angella, however, gave Bow her best tragic look.

"I beseech thee, cruel pirate, have mercy. A poor mother can but hope that you will find it in your blackened heart to reunite a grieving parent with her only child."

"Oh, um, of course!"

"After you get the cookies!" Glimmer hissed from the tree house. Angella widened her eyes and looked around. "Hark! I hear my daughter's voice! Is she near?"

"No, no!" Bow waved his hands in front of him. "It's just my... parrot. Up in the tree."

Angella gave him a bemused look. "Your parrot, oh dread pirate?"

"Squack! Walk the plank, landlubbers! Polly wants a cookie!" Glimmer squaked, making Juliet have to hid another fit of laughter.

Angella nodded gravely. "Then we have no other choice then to provide the noble bird with its requested prize." She held up a cookie tin that smelled deliciously of vanilla. "Just tell me one thing, oh villainous scoundrel."

"Of course, Queen Angella... I mean, maybe. It depends on the question."

Angella looked Bow in the eyes. "Of all the princesses in the world, why did you see fit to kidnap princess Glimmer?"

"Because..." Glimmer begun in her parrot voice, but Bow beat her to it. "Because she's pretty."

There was a moment of stunned silence as both Angella and Glimmer (peaking out from the tree house) stared at Bow. He nervously licked his lips. "...um, I mean... as a pirate I collect pretty things for my booty" -Juliet clamped her hand before her mouth- "and princess Glimmer is the prettiest of all princesses of Etheria."

"I am?" Glimmer said before she remembered her role. "I mean, she is? Squak?"

"She absolutely is," Bow confidently said. She is pretty as a sunset and smells like a cookie. She is brave like a hero and she is..." -he blushed slightly- "she is the best friend... um, I mean, prisoner, one could ever wish for."

Angella gave him a warm look, ignoring Glimmer's surprised parrot noises from the tree "Such a discerning eye, for a villain. It makes me surprised, though, that you are willing to give such a treasure up for just a tin of cookies."

"You can't keep someone as brave and resourceful locked up for long," Bow confidently said. "She will find a way to be free, no matter how clever you think you are."

"Yes, I suppose you are right," Angella sighed, a clear tone of melancholia in her voice. "A free spirit such as hers will find a way to overcome whatever restrictions may be placed in her way."

"We still need the cookies, though. Squak!" Glimmer quickly interjected.

"And cookies you shall have." Angella opened the jar to reveal a veritable treasure trove of crisp, golden vanilla biscuits. I just have one final request."

"You are in no position to make demands. Squak!"

"I *request* my daughter to be returned safe to her quarters, no later than two hours before midnight, with brushed teeth and ready for bed."

"That is acceptable," Glimmer quickly said from the tree house. "Squak."

"Then I bid thee farewell, oh noble pirate, and I pray for my daughter's safe return."

"Enjoy your 'booty'," Juliet tittered, and promptly received a slap on the arm from Angella.

"Thanks so much, queen Angella!" Bow happily said before he remembered his role. "I mean, avast. I now return to my dread pirate ship. Yarrrrr."

Angella and Juliet turned around, and immediately saw the telltale pink flash as Bow and the cookie tin were teleported back to the tree house.

"I like that boy," Angella mused as they made their way back through the garden, ignoring the excited children's voices from the tree house.

"A perfect little gentleman," Juliet agreed. "And a much needed voice of reason for the princess, if I may be so bold. If only she would occasionally listen to him, that is."

"I so wish Micah could have met Bow," Angella sighed. "He would have loved him."

"He would," Juliet agreed. "He would have loved both of them."

Angella chuckled. "Did I ever tell you about the time when he kidnapped me?"

Juliet sharply turned. "Micah *kidnapped you?*"

"It was during our period of courtship... before your time obviously," Angella hurriedly said. "And we made our best to hide it from gossip not to cause... untimely speculation."

"I can see why," Juliet mused. "Still, he must have made an impression, if you decided to marry him after that."

Angella smiled at the memory. "Let's just say that the whole affair came to involve quite a bit of 'booty'."

"*Angella!*"

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